

GEOSTRATEGIC IMPORTANCE OF PAKISTAN

Pakistan is the Land of Pure, is strategically placed at the crossroads of Asia. The official name of the state is Islamic Republic of Pakistan. Capital of Pakistan is Islamabad but the first capital of Pakistan was Karachi from 1947 to 1959. Then President of Pakistan Ayub Khan shifted the capital from Karachi to Islamabad in 1959.



LOCATION OF PAKISTAN AND NEIGHBOURS

- Pakistan is located between 23.5 degree North to 37 degree North and 61 degree East to 77 degree East as far as the latitudinal and longitudinal extents are concerned.

- Pakistan is surrounded by various countries:

East.....	India	(1650 Km Radcliffe line)
West & North West	Afghanistan	(2250 Km Durand line)
N. West.....	Tajikistan	(Wakhan Strip)27 km
South West	Iran	(900 Km Gold Smith Line)
North.....	China	(523 Km Sino-Pak border)
South.....	Arabian Sea	(1046 Km Coastal line)

AREA OF PAKISTAN

- Pakistan came into being on August 14, 1947. Its official name is Islamic Republic of Pakistan. It has an area of 7,96,096 square kilometers.
- Area of Pakistan is four times as large as UK and one fourth of the size of India. 58% area of Pakistan is consists of Mountains and plateaus, while 42% area of Pakistan consists of plains and deserts.
- Pakistan's latest estimated population is 207,774,520 according to the 2017 Census of Pakistan. Pakistan is the world's fifth-most-populous country.

DEMOGRAPHICS

- **Population** 220,892,340 people (2020)
- **Growth rate** 2.50 (2020)
- **Birth rate** 29.8 births / 1,000 population (2016)
- **Death rate** 7.5 deaths / 1,000 population (2016)
- **Life expectancy** 67.7 years (2016)
 - male 65.8 years (2016)
 - female 69.8 years (2016)
- **Fertility rate** 3.56 children born / woman (2016)
- **Infant mortality rate** 53.86 deaths / 1,000 live births (2016)

- **Literacy rate** **62.3% (2018)**
 - Male:** **72.5%**
 - Female:** **51.8%**
- **Ethnic groups in Pakistan**
 - Punjabi 44.7%
 - Pashtun 15.4%
 - Sindhi 14.1%
 - Saraiki 8.4%
 - Muhajir 7.6%
 - Balochi 3.6%
 - Other 6.3%

- **Languages of Pakistan (2017)**

Punjabi	44.2%
Pashto	15.4%
Sindhi	14.1%
Saraiki	10.5%
Urdu	7.6%
Balochi	3.6%
Hindko	2.0%
Brahui	1.04%
Others	1.65%

- **Religion in Pakistan (2017)**

Islam	(96.06%)
Hinduism	(1.92%)
Christianity	(1.72%)
Other religions	(0.30%)

- **Important Rivers Of Pakistan**

PUNJAB Jhelum , Chenab , Ravi , Sutlej

SINDH Hub , Mir Nadi , Arl Nadi

KPK Indus , Kabul , Swat , Bara , Chitral , Zhob , Panjkora , Gomal , Kurram

BALUCHISTAN Hangol , Nari , Bolan , Dasht , Mula , Rakhshan , Pashin Lora

MOUNTAIN PASSES OF PAKISTAN

Muztagh Pass, Karakoram Pass, Khan kun Pass, Zagar Pass, Kilik Pass, Khunjrab Pass, Mintaka Pass, Dorath Pass, Babusar Pass, Shandur Pass, Lowari Pass, Buroghil Pass, Khyber Pass, Shimshal Pass, Ganshero Pass, Tochi Pass, Gomal Pass, Durgai Pass, Malakand Pass

GEOSTRATEGY

- **Geo** means the **Earth** and **strategy** means planning, **tactics** and **policy**. The term "**geo-strategy**" was first used by Frederick L. Schuman in his 1942 article "**Let Us Learn Our Geopolitics.**" It was a translation of the German term "Wehrgeopolitik" as used by German geo-strategist Karl Haushofer.
- Many geo-strategists are also geographers, specializing in subfields of geography, such as human geography, political geography, economic geography, cultural geography, military geography, and strategic geography.

- “**Geo strategic** means the importance of a country or a region as by virtue of its geographical location. Geo political is defined as, stressing the influence of geographic factors on the state power, international conduct and advantages it derives from its location.”
- “Geopolitical reflects the combination of geographic and political factors determining the condition of a state or region, and emphasizing the impact of geography on politics.”
- Stephen Cohn describes this importance

“While history has been unkind to Pakistan, its geography has been its greatest benefit. It has resource rich area in the north-west, people rich in the north-east.”



GEOGRAPHICAL IMPORTANCE

- Pakistan is located at a region which has great political, economic and strategic location. It has been hub of activities of great powers for last 20 years. It has witnessed intervention of three great powers i-e Britain, USSR, and USA.
- Its significance was further enhanced during cold war when it becomes ally of US policy of containment of USSR and now the post cold war era has witnessed its significance particularly after the events of 9/11.
- The geographic location of Pakistan makes it a junction of the three important parts of the world. South Asia, West Asia and Central Asia.

- Pakistan is thus located in one of the most sensitive regions of the world where global rivalries of great power, accentuated by local rivalries came into conflict with each other and serve to heighten Pakistan's security concerns.
- Safeguarding its security is, therefore, a principal aim of Pakistan's foreign policy even under normal circumstances. In today's troubled times, it has become foremost preoccupation. Pakistan's geostrategic position is such that since its creation, it has faced a succession of challenging situations.
- In recent years, the problems in the region have multiplied in a way that has focused world's attention on Pakistan.

- Pakistan is located at the junction of great powers. In its neighbors one world power Russia and the other emerging power China lies. Any alliance among world powers enhances its significance. This factor has been utilized by Pakistan after 9/11.

Main Points

- Proximity of Great powers
- Gateway to Central Asia
- Significance as a Transit economy
- Important link in the chain of Muslim countries
- Only Muslim country with nuclear capability
- China's link to the Middle East
- Reduce Indian hegemony in the Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean

PROXIMITY OF GREAT POWERS

- Russia and China are busy to give check to US Power in this region and in other regions like Middle East, Africa, North America, Europe and Far East Asia

US Interests

- US interests in the regions is to contain the Growing China, nuclear Iran, terrorist Afghanistan, and to benefit from the market of India. **Security** and **Business** are two main US interests in the region while Pakistan is playing a front line role against terrorism.
- Today the political scenario of the region is tinged with pre emptio policy and US invasion of Iraq and Afghanistan, Iran's nuclear program, India's geopolitical muscles(new strategic deal with US) to gain the hegemony and to counter the **Rise of China** which has earned all the qualities to change unipolar world into Bipolar world.

Strategic and Economic Interests of China

- Arrival of US troops in Afghanistan- doorstep of China that it agreed to construct Gwadar port in 2002 and funded \$ 198 million, with 450 workers and technical assistance, while Pakistan shared \$ 50 million for phase 1.
- **Benefit to China:** Beijing will get considerable influence in the Persian Gulf, entrance to the Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean, while closely monitor US naval activity and US Indian maritime cooperation.
- The port will enable China to monitor its energy shipments (60% of its oil need) from the Persian Gulf, and energy imports from Central Asia. Having no blue water navy, China feels defenseless in the Persian Gulf. President Musharaf's statement, "when needed the Chinese Navy could be in Gwadar to give befitting replies to every one."

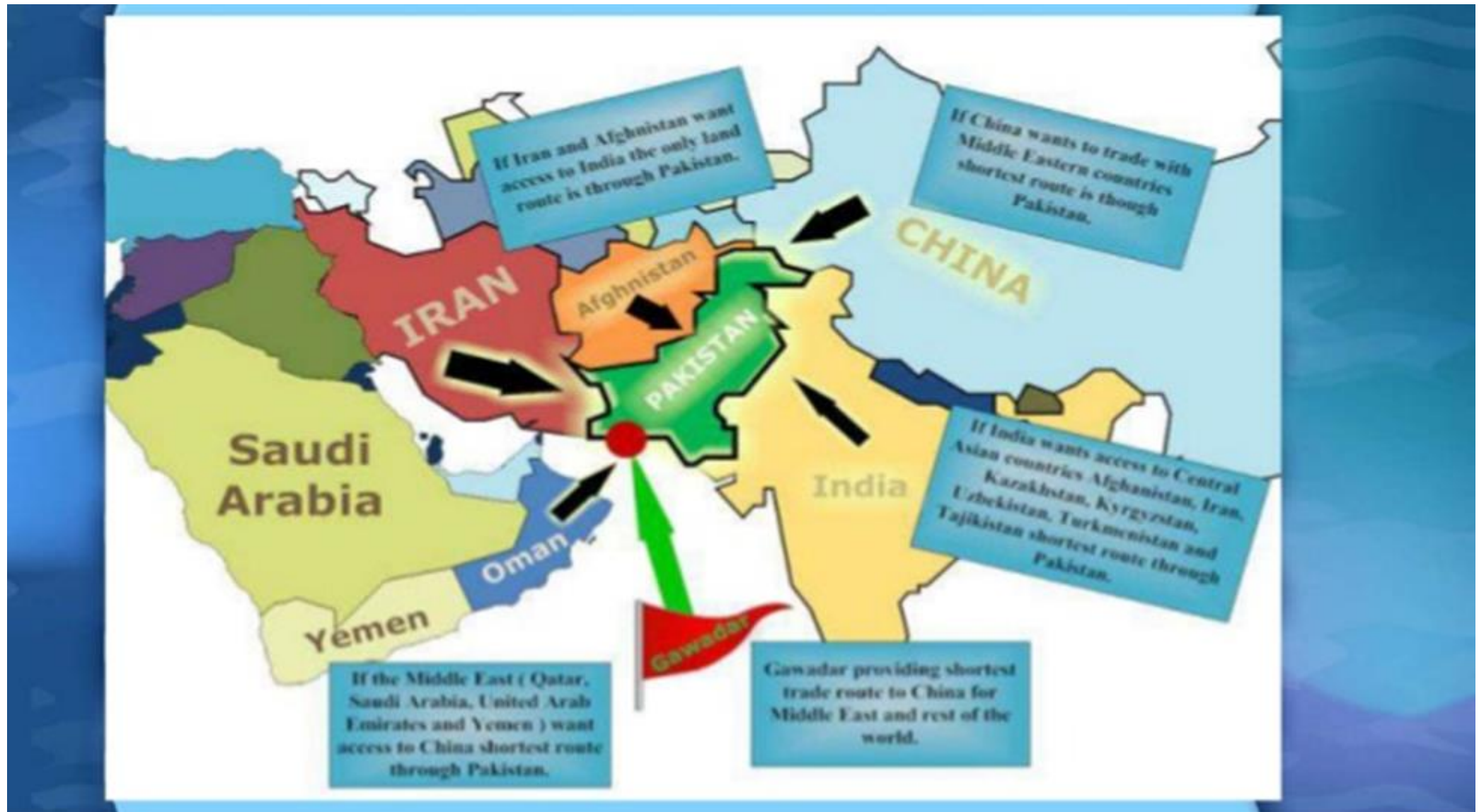


GATEWAY TO CENTRAL ASIA

- Central Asia is the center stage of new Great games: Western quest for resources- oil and energy resources in the Central Asia
- Pakistan is located very close to the oil rich M.E region and C.A States and Pakistan can influence shipment of oil
- In the energy scarce world, Pakistan is located in the hub of energy rich countries i-e Iran and Afghanistan: both are energy abundant while India and China are lacking.
- China finds way to Indian Ocean and Arabian sea through Karakoram highway, Pakistan through Arabian Sea is linked with the Muslims Countries of Persian Gulf. All of them are rich in oil. In Karachi Bin Qasim and Gwadar are important seaports of Pakistan

SIGNIFICANCE AS TRANSIT ECONOMY

- Land locked Afghanistan now at the phase of reconstruction finds its ways through Pakistan
- China with its fastest economy growth rate of 9% GDP developing southern provinces.
- Pakistan offers central Asian regions the shortest route of 2600 km as compared to Iran 4500 km or turkey 5000 km
- Iran is struggling to export its surplus gas and oil to Eastern countries, Qatar, Pakistan and Turkmenistan pipeline IPI projects highlight this position
- Pakistan would get 400 million dollar annually if IPI gets success. Mountain Ranges: Himalayas, Hindu Kush in the North are plentiful in providing water and natural resources.
- Gwadar Port with its deep waters attracts the trade ships of China, CARs and south east Asian countries



GEO-POLITICAL IMPORTANCE OF GAWADAR PORT

- Gwadar is located on the southwestern coast of Pakistan, close to the important Straits of Hormuz, through which more than 13 million bpd of oil passes.
- It is strategically located between three increasingly important regions of the world: the oil-rich **Middle East**, heavily populated **South Asia** and the economically emerging and resource-rich **Central Asia**.
- **Dubai is the hub of business** not only for Gulf but also for rest of the world including Europe, United States, Africa, China and Central Asian States, simultaneously. The gulf region is facing many political conflicts and huge disturbances in the current situation.
- In such a scenario, a substitute of Dubai is essential to be located before the crisis hits the finances of millions. The substitute shall be a nearest point probably, to ensure continuous supply line of oil from Gulf to the outer world. Fortunately, Gawadar proves to be the nearest and in fact more cost-effective substitute of Dubai, from many aspects.

- **China is emerging** as a super economic power of the world in the recent years. Despite occupying a huge area of world's land, it doesn't have any port of hot waters, which can be used the whole year. Gawadar port is only on a distance of 2500 km from China and the port is working for the whole year because of the hot waters here.
- **The central Asian states**, after the independence from USSR, are trying to develop their economies. These states are land locked and Karachi was expected to provide them the services through Afghanistan. For the purpose, a highway from Peshawar to Karachi was constructed but due to Afghan crisis, this line couldn't be established. The Afghan situation is till not clear, so, Gawadar being near to Iranian border will provide port facilities to Central Asia as well.

NATURAL RESOURCES

- Those resources which Allah has created for every type of life are called natural resources. These natural resources are Waters, Forests, Minerals, Soil and Mountains etc.
- It is believed that the most vital factor which can be helpful for any country is the natural resources. And Pakistan is a blessed country due to its natural resources. Pakistan has the world's fifth largest gold mine in Baluchistan, world's second largest salt mine in Punjab and world's sixth coal mine also in Punjab.
- Pakistan has three of the biggest mountains of the world. It is said that these mountain ranges serve us safe from Siberia winds. The huge glaciers supply water in the rivers. Our huge market makes it an avid hub for export of the commodities by our neighbours.

IMPORTANT CHAIN IN THE MUSLIM WORLD

- Geographically, Pakistan is situated at the center of the Islamic countries of Africa and Asia
- It is linked to these Muslim states through land and sea routes and thus not only its ideological background, but its geographical centrality necessities that it supports the unity of Muslim world
- Prior to the cessation of East Pakistan, it was the largest Islamic state and naturally was in the vanguard of the movement for Islamic unity
- Even afterwards, it actively works for the mutual alliance and unity of the Muslims
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ONLY MUSLIM COUNTRY WITH NUCLEAR CAPABILITY

- Pakistan became an atomic power in 1998 when Pakistan made atomic blasts at Chaghi. Pakistan is also the first Islamic Power in the region where the Pakistan is situated with India, China and Russia also other atomic powers
- Pakistan is the only Muslim country having nuclear capability which has great influence on the political, socio-economic activities in the region and the maintenance of status quo in the region.
- Pakistan' s strategic position in the world has been considerably increased ever since it has achieved nuclear capability, which has made it the only Muslim country armed with atomic weapons.

STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP WITH CHINA

- Pakistan recognized China in 1951 and 1961 voted for restoration of Communist China's rights in the UN. Sino Indian war 1962 culminated in close friendship; in 1963 an agreement on border was signed. Pakistan, during peak days of cold war (1970), facilitated visit of Henry Kissinger (US Foreign Secretary) to China. This led to Nixon's visit to China which eased the rising tension between them.
- Initially Pak-China's strategic partnership was driven by the mutual need to counter the Soviet Union and India. China supported Pakistan in its wars against India with military and economic assistance. China assisted in developing Pakistan's Nuclear Program, enhanced trade and investment

Recent Developments

- Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation signed in 2005 “Neither party will join any alliance which infringes upon the sovereignty, security and territorial integrity.”
- China role in SCO and Pakistan membership
- Trade: \$ 6 billion in 2010 whereas has risen to \$ 18 billion by 2019
- China invested \$13 billion in Gwadar

ECONOMIC BLOCS

- Pakistan is an active and important member of regional organizations like SAARC, ASEAN, SCO and ECO.
- Gawadar port with its deep waters attracts the trade ships of China, Central Asian Republics and South East Asian Countries.

GAS PIPELINES

- IP
- TAPI
- Qatar Turkmenistan Pakistan pipeline

CHINA-PAKISTAN ECONOMIC CORRIDOR

- Pakistan benefits from its strategic location and China is taking advantage of that. Around 80% of China's trade and energy imports travel through the pirate-swarmed Strait of Malacca and Indian Ocean, both patrolled by the United States and Indian Navies.
- These possible chokepoints at Malacca Strait are a security issue for China, particularly regarding oil as 40% of China's general consumption passes through the Malacca Strait. Any conflict could block the China's energy supply, as a result, supply ships would need to travel an extra 500 miles to avoid the Malacca Strait, currently the fastest route from the Indian Ocean to the Pacific. China is aware of this vulnerability and is looking to Pakistan to provide a shorter and safer alternative

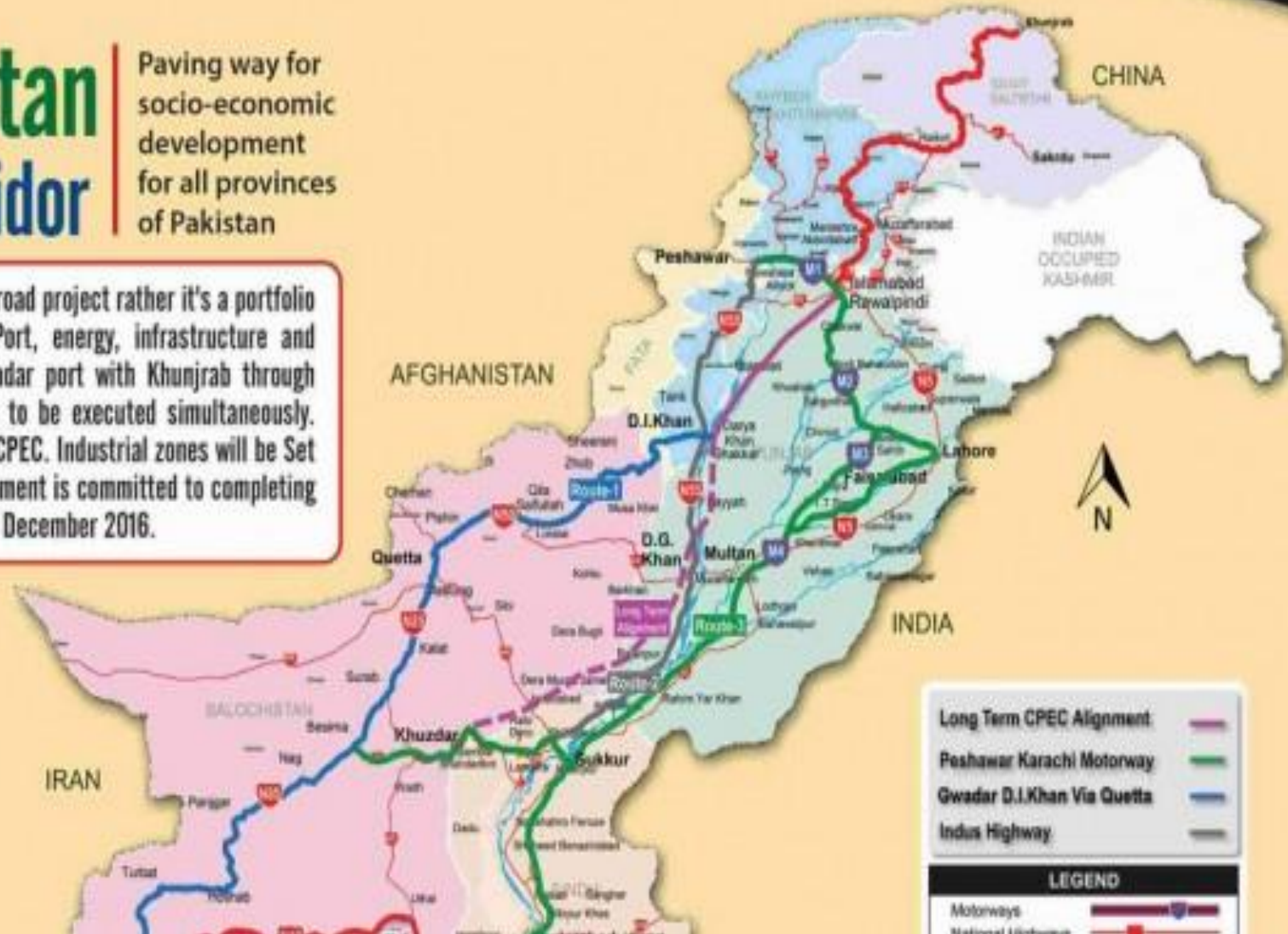
China-Pakistan Economic Corridor

Paving way for socio-economic development for all provinces of Pakistan

CPEC is not just a name of any single road project rather it's a portfolio of projects which include Gwadar Port, energy, infrastructure and industrial zones. It will connect Gwadar port with Khunjrab through Western, Central and Eastern routes to be executed simultaneously. There is no change in original plan of CPEC. Industrial zones will be Set up in all the provinces. Elected government is committed to completing the western route on priority basis till December 2016.

Salient Features:

- 16,400 Mega Watt additional electricity through coal, hydel, wind and solar energy;
- 2400 km trade corridor between Kashghar (China) and Gwadar through different routes;
- Upgradation and modernization of Karachi-Peshawar Railway track (ML-T);
- Establishment of new economic zones in all 4 provinces and regions;
- Development of port infrastructure and



- The Pakistan-China Economic Corridor will move from KHUNJERAB PASS into Pakistan in the mountains down Karakorum Highway. At an altitude of more than 15,000 feet, outnumber cargo trucks will be crossing over Pakistan's border with China. The initial outlines of this corridor are already visible, where the highway snakes past mountains, glaciers, and rocky valleys. From central Pakistan, more roads will be built to provide access to Gwadar Port in Baluchistan.
- The \$46 billion 'China-Pakistan Economic Corridor' scheme, which is being demonstrated as a 'Game-Changer' is more than a network of roads to link Chinese city of Kashghar with the Gulf States via Gwadar of Pakistan. CPEC is a complete package of energy projects and trade opportunities for Pakistan. It is the most cherished fruit of Pakistan's geographical importance the country ever had.

CONCLUSION

- Pakistan's geography where brought the country countless material benefits there its unwise exploitation also invited the chaos in the region. Being the gateway to Central Asia and a suitable route of access of World Powers into land-locked Afghanistan, the geography of Pakistan suffered from the side effects of the 'New Great Game' and the 'Global War on Terrorism'.
- But things are in transformation today. The Northern border with China where gets ready to bring billion dollars investment in the wake of CPEC there the Western border with Afghanistan is seeking TAPI Gas Pipeline. Similarly, the South Western boundary with Iran will sooner or later be flexible for Pak-Iran Gas Pipeline. Pakistan's newly functional port of Gwadar and the strategic importance it has concerning its proximity to the Gulf States are some new aspects of Pakistan's geographical importance.

- Interaction and inter linkage of trade and transport provides the most potent input for economic cross fertilization to Pakistan. Realization of this potential could mark an impressive addition to our economic capacities.
- Sincere leadership, social adaptability, regional alliances especially with China, Iran, CAR's, resolution of issues with India, visionary qualities will make all of us independent from all socio-economic strains and financial dependencies.
- This is the way how Pakistan can translate its strategic and geographic importance into the goal of ambitious, glorious, perfect and developed Pakistan.